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US Economics Weekly

Cooling inflation increasingly hard to ignore

CITI'S TAKE

A second consecutive month of soft jobs and inflation data led markets to significantly reduce the probability of a new Fed hiking cycle. We expect August data – released just before the September FOMC meeting – to stay similarly weak, which should all but rule out higher policy rates in coming months. Chair Warsh's August 28th speech at Jackson Hole has the potential to be a dovish market event if Warsh chooses to use it to set up Fed actions over the remainder of the year. We continue to expect the next Fed policy action to be a rate cut, with a base case for 25bp cuts in October, December and January.

Andrew Hollenhorst^{AC}

+1-212-816-0325

andrew.hollenhorst@citi.com

Veronica Clark^{AC}

+1-212-816-8830

veronica1.clark@citi.com

See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and Research Analyst Affiliations.

For a second consecutive month, jobs data has been surprisingly soft and core inflation has come in cool. The market-implied probability of rate hikes fell significantly, but there is still about 33bp of tightening priced-in through the middle of next year. This indicates most investors have a base-case for the Fed to remain on hold but are affording some probability of potential hikes. Increased uncertainty around Fed actions may keep some hike premium reflected in interest rates until the next jobs report (September 4th) absent a dovish indication from Chair Warsh at the August 28th FOMC meeting.

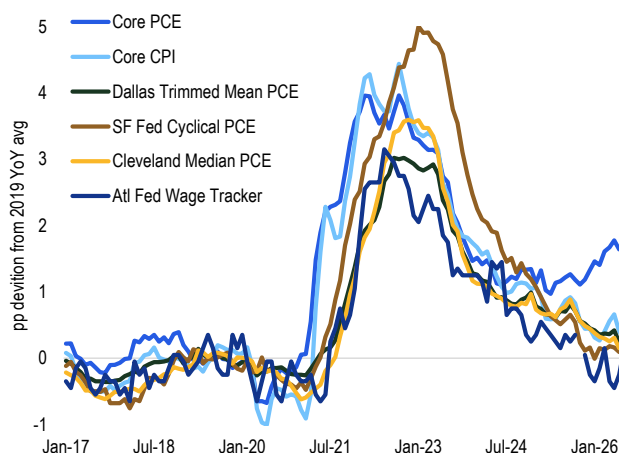
Figure 1. The market is pricing-out Fed hikes



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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg

The message from the broad range of underlying inflation metrics continues to be that inflation is within 50bp of target and trending lower. Core CPI came in at 0.215%MoM and 2.48%YoY in July – consistent with that understanding. The slowdown in core inflation has been broad-based, and we expect the August report will follow June and July with a 0.2%MoM rounded reading – typical in the pre-pandemic low inflation era. Base effects mean core CPI should shift down to 2.3%YoY, exactly the rate that Fed officials have historically considered consistent with price-stability.

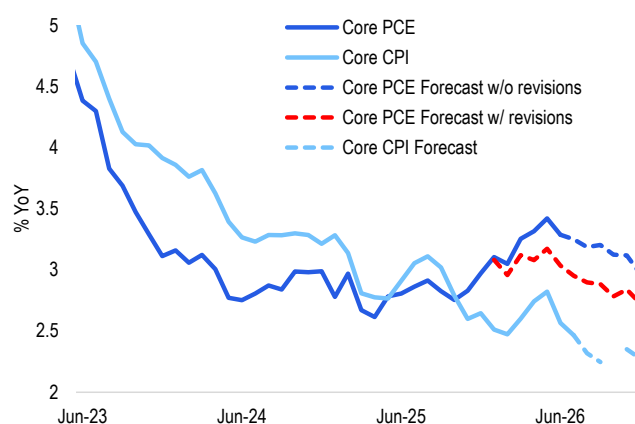
Figure 2. Underlying inflation is slowing across a broad range of measures



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Source: Citi Research, BLS, BEA

Figure 3. Core CPI and core PCE should continue slowing



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Source: Citi Research, BLS, BEA

PPI prices advanced slower than expected. Over the last two months core goods prices have increased at the slowest rate since 2024, indicating that higher energy costs that boosted transportation costs in prior months have not, and likely will not, be passed through to final consumer prices.

Details of core CPI and PPI imply a benign 0.21%MoM core PCE reading in July following 0.13%MoM in June. Portfolio management fees – which move with equity prices – were up a stronger-than-expected 6.5%MoM in PPI and led us to raise our projection for July core PCE from 0.15% to 0.21%MoM. The BEA is planning to significantly revise the methodology for computing portfolio management fees when August data is released in September, meaning this uplift may be largely revised away.

Core PCE will remain an outlier amongst other underlying inflation metrics at 3.2–3.3%YoY which we project will fall to a still-elevated 2.7–2.8%YoY by the end of the year (including downward revisions worth 20–30bp on the year-on-year reading). But we think the Fed interpretation will grow increasingly less hawkish in coming months as sequential monthly readings remain around target, downward revisions remind officials that the PCE methodology is not accurately reflecting consumer prices and it becomes increasingly hard to ignore the plethora of other signals (CPI, wages, trimmed-mean inflation, median inflation) that are showing underlying inflation close to if not already at target.

Retail sales were much softer than consensus with total sales down 0.6%MoM in July and the control group declining 0.4%MoM. The decline was due to falling sales of motor vehicles and an aberrantly large 2.25%MoM decline in online sales, which should partially rebound next month. Still, other categories advanced only modestly and a slowdown in consumer spending would be consistent with slower job and real income growth and the already-low savings rate. Following strong Q2 spending, the one month of data will not significantly shift the economic outlook but is yet another reason for the Fed to remain on-hold and makes upcoming spending data more market relevant.

Chair Warsh is expected to give his Jackson Hole address on August 28th but at the July press conference he said he was undecided about whether he would focus on

the “big picture” or instead set the table for policy action over the remainder of the year. Given his no-guidance approach, we would not expect an explicit discussion of policy action in September or beyond. But with the last two months of softer jobs and cooler inflation data, risks skew dovish. For instance, Warsh might review the work so far by the taskforces and implicitly endorse the idea that most inflation metrics do not point to a need to hike policy rates.

We maintain our call for the next Fed move to be a cut rather than a hike. Cooling inflation already gives the Fed a strong reason not to raise rates. For the Fed to cut rates, renewed concerns about the labor market would need to creep in. The last two months of data have clarified that while the unemployment rate is technically “stable,” job growth averaging just 20k per month and rapidly falling labor force participation make it not entirely “healthy.” In our base case, payrolls growth will stay weak in coming months (readings around zero or slightly negative in August and September) and the unemployment rate will rise, pushing the Fed to cut rates by 25bp in October, December and January.

Next Week- FOMC Minutes overshadowed by softer data

Next week’s FOMC minutes should largely reinforce what is already known: a divided Committee, including three dissents in favor of raising rates. That said, the discussion will likely feel somewhat stale given that it predates the recent run of softer data, which has shifted the policy narrative in a more dovish direction.

We expect July industrial production to decline modestly, likely due to temporary weakness in auto manufacturing, though the broader manufacturing outlook remains supported by AI-related investment and tax incentives. Consistent with this, we expect both manufacturing and services PMI readings to remain in expansion territory, while the employment component will be watched for signs of further labor market cooling.

Meanwhile, housing starts are likely to decline in July, led by weaker multifamily construction, while higher mortgage rates continue to weigh on single-family building. We also expect jobless claims to edge higher in August, consistent with a gradually cooling labor market.

Veronica Clark

Industrial Production – Citi: -0.1%, median: 0.3%, prior: 0.1%

Manufacturing Production – Citi: -0.3%, median: 0.2%, prior: 0.0%

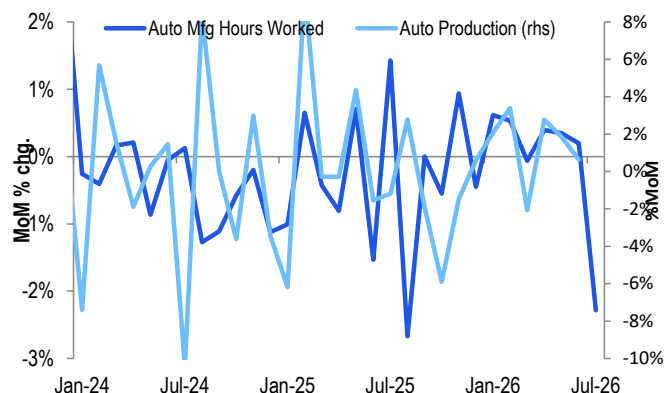
Capacity Utilization – Citi: 76.0%, median: 76.3%, prior: 76.1%

We expect a modest 0.1%MoM decline in total industrial production in July with a slightly larger 0.3% decline in manufacturing production. Some of these weaknesses could be due to the auto sector, as hours worked in auto manufacturing showed a large decline in July. This may be related to usual summer auto holidays, which can shift around during the summer weeks and thus may be difficult to adjust for in seasonal adjustments. If auto production is weak in July, there could be a bounce-back in August/September.

In general, most manufacturing data have been very strong, related to AI-investment and build-out, as well as support for investment from tax incentives introduced this year. But notably, hard data on manufacturing production has been a bit softer over the last few months. As much of the AI-investment goods have been imported, domestic production has not been quite as supported (private final domestic demand rose a strong 3.9% annualized in Q2, real GDP only rose 1.5%).

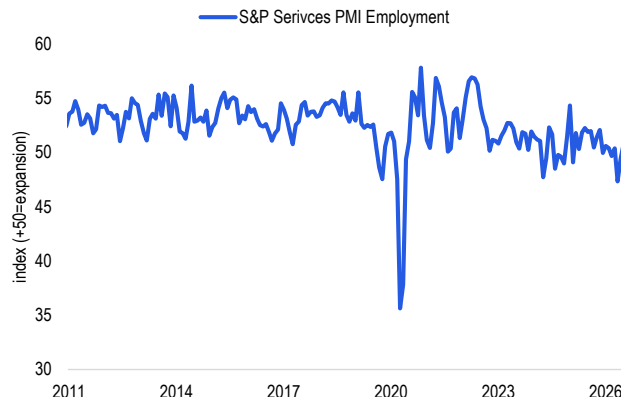
Industrial production data, reported in real terms, will continue to be an important signal of the strength of domestic activity.

Figure 4. Auto production may be soft in July



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Source: Citi Research, Federal Reserve Bank

Figure 5. Services employment PMI has been soft over the last few years



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Source: Citi Research, S&P

S&P US Manufacturing PMI – Citi: 54.3, median: 53.8, prior: 53.9

S&P US Services PMI – Citi: 54.5, median: 53.9, prior: 54.6

We expect a modest increase in the S&P Manufacturing PMI index in preliminary August data, to 54.3. Manufacturing data broadly have been consistently strong this year, with the exception of some recent easing in industrial production. Strength in manufacturing largely reflects a combination of AI-related investment demand and other support for investment such as tax incentives from the OBBBA. While demand from the AI-build out will likely continue, these other investment incentives will fade into the end of the year.

The Services PMI index should be little changed at 54.5 in preliminary August data, suggesting continued solid activity in the broader economy. Of the various services PMI details, we are most interested in the employment component. While not always correlated with jobs data month-to-month (PMI employment rebounded in July while payrolls declined), the index has modestly softened in recent years, consistent with the still-low-hiring environment.

Housing Starts – Citi: 1313k, median: 1350k, prior: 1427k

Housing Starts MoM – Citi: -8.0%, median: -5.8%, prior: 19.0%

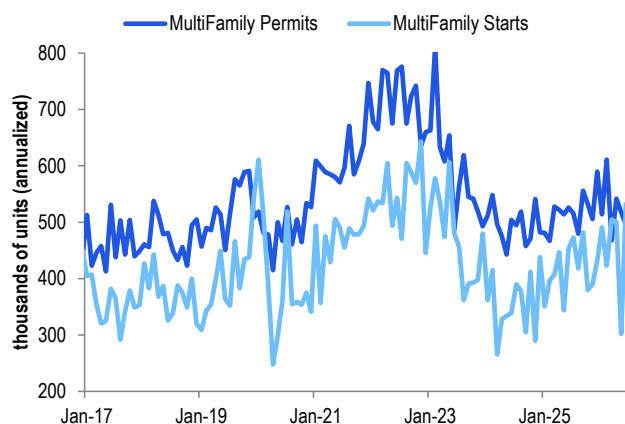
Building Permits – Citi: 1400k, median: 1369k, prior: 1374k

Building Permits MoM – Citi: 1.9%, median: NA, prior: -2.6%

Housing starts have been very volatile over the last few months, driven by large swings in construction of multifamily units. We expect this volatility to continue in July with an 8% decline in total starts to 1313k. Our forecast includes another pullback in multifamily units. Despite the rebound in multifamily starts in June after a drop in May, permits of multifamily units have been much more subdued. Multifamily permits have even started to modestly decline on average over the last few months after rising throughout 2025. This should suggest that further upside to multifamily starts is limited. Single family housing construction has been much more stable, but with both starts and permits of single-family units near recent lows of the last few years. High mortgage rates, an elevated number of new homes

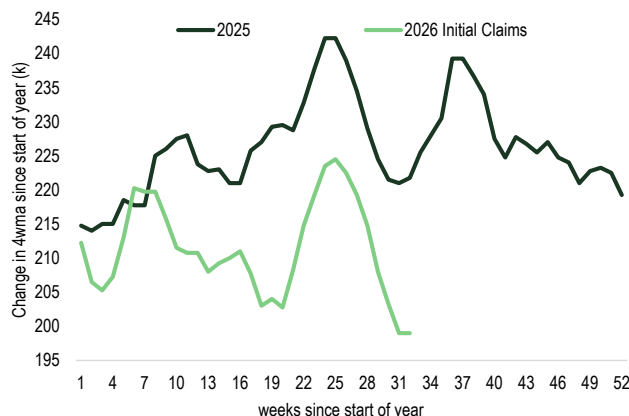
already for sale, and possible labor challenges with changes in immigration policy should all weigh on new housing construction in coming months.

Figure 6. Multifamily construction has been volatile over the last few months



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Source: Citi Research, Bureau of the Census

Figure 7. Initial jobless claims are following a familiar pattern as last year



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Source: Citi Research, DOL

Initial Jobless Claims – Citi: 213k, median: NA, prior: 209k
Continuing Claims – Citi: 1787k, median: NA, prior: 1777k

Initial jobless claims have been very low in recent weeks but should start to rise further through the month of August in line with familiar seasonal patterns. We expect another modest increase in initial claims to 213k for the week of August 15 and for continuing claims to rise to 1787k the week of August 8. Rising claims in August could signal continued weak job growth next month, although it was somewhat surprising to see very low claims correspond with job losses in July payrolls. Still, we think the most important takeaway from claims data is that familiar seasonal patterns are repeating again this year. In our base case, this means more months of softer labor market data, most importantly an increase in the unemployment rate into the fall as has been the pattern the last few years.

Fed Monitor

Figure 8. FOMC ranked from hawkish to dovish

Name	Position	2026 Voter	2027 Voter	2028 Voter	Term Exp.
Hammack	Cleveland Fed	Y	N	Y	2031
Logan	Dallas Fed	Y	N	N	2031
Schmid	Kansas City Fed	N	N	Y	2031
Musalem	St Louis Fed	N	N	Y	2031
Barkin	Richmond Fed	N	Y	N	2028
Venable*	Atlanta Fed	N	Y	N	interim
Barr	Board of Governors	Y	Y	Y	2032
Kashkari	Minneapolis Fed	Y	N	N	2031
Goolsbee	Chicago Fed	N	Y	N	2031
Collins	Boston Fed	N	N	Y	2031
Powell	Board of Governors	Y	Y	Y	2028
Jefferson	Board of Governors	Y	Y	Y	2036
Waller	Board of Governors	Y	Y	Y	2030
Warsh	Board of Governors (Chair)	Y	Y	Y	2030
Paulson	Philadelphia Fed	Y	N	N	2031
Cook	Board of Governors	Y	Y	Y	2038
Daly	SF Fed	N	Y	N	2028
Williams	New York Fed	Y	Y	Y	2031
Bowman	Board of Governors	Y	Y	Y	2034

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* Venable is a temporarily representing Atl Fed at Fed meetings until a new President has been chosen.

Source: Citi Research

Figure 9. Who's who in the Jun FOMC Dot Plot, in our view

	2026	2027
4.375	Schmid	Schmid
4.25		
4.125	Hammack, Logan, Musalem, Barkin, Kashkari	Hammack, Musalem
4		
3.875	Atl Fed*, Collins, Goolsbee	Barkin, Atl Fed, Kashkari, Goolsbee, Logan
3.75		
3.625	Daly, Paulson, Waller, Powell, Jefferson, Barr, Cook, Williams	Williams, Collins
3.5		
3.375	Bowman	Jefferson, Barr, Cook
3.25		
3.125		Powell, Waller, Daly, Paulson
3		
2.875		Bowman
2.75		

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Source: Citi Research

Figure 10. Citi Policy Rate Forecast

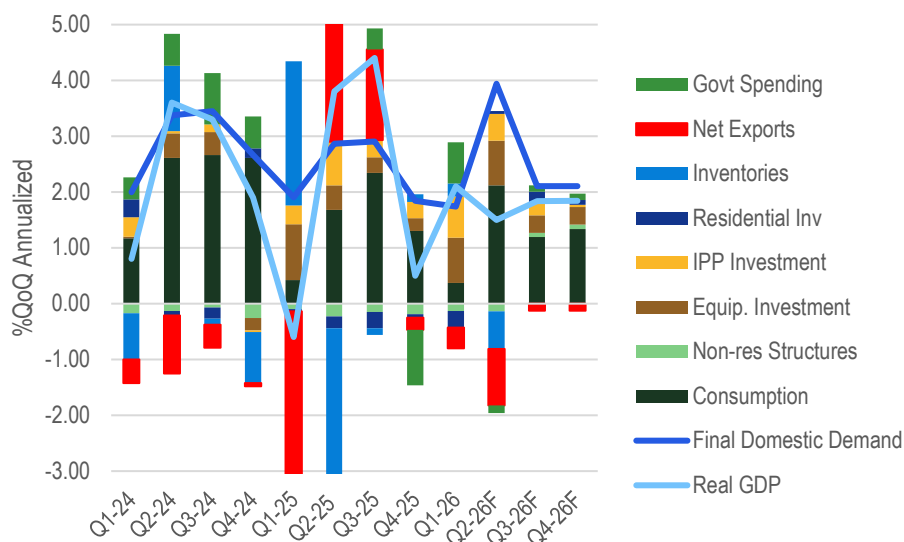
Fed Meeting	Citi Forecast	
	Policy Range	Change
16-Sep-26	3.5-3.75	0
28-Oct-26	3.25-3.5	-0.25
9-Dec-26	3.0-3.25	-0.25
27-Jan-27	2.75-3.0	-0.25
17-Mar-27	2.75-3.0	0
28-Apr-27	2.75-3.0	0
9-Jun-27	2.75-3.0	0
28-Jul-27	2.75-3.0	0
15-Sep-27	2.75-3.0	0
27-Oct-27	2.75-3.0	0
8-Dec-27	2.75-3.0	0

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Source: Citi Research

GDP Tracking

We expect a 1.8% increase in Q3 2026 real GDP.

Figure 11. GDP growth tracking



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Source: Citi Research, Bureau of Economic Analysis

Figure 12. Q3 2026 GDP forecast and contributions

Component	Citi		Atlanta Fed	
	As Of Aug-14	1wk chg	As of Aug-14	1wk chg
Consumption	1.2	0.0	1.7	-0.4
Business Structures	0.1	0.0	0.0	0.0
Business Equipment	0.3	0.0	0.4	0.0
IPP	0.2	0.0	0.4	0.0
Residential	0.2	0.0	0.0	0.0
Final Private Domestic Demand	2.0	0.0	2.5	-0.4
Inventories	0.0	0.0	1.8	-0.1
Government	0.1	0.0	0.2	0.0
Net Exports	-0.1	0.0	-0.2	0.0
GDP (QoQ SAAR)	1.8	0.0	4.3	-0.5

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Source: Citi Research, Atlanta Fed

Inflation Forecasts

Figure 13. Citi 12-month Inflation forecasts versus market pricing

Month	Market Pricing			Citi Forecasts					
	CPI NSA Index	CPI YoY	Implied Core*	CPI NSA Index	CPI YoY	Core CPI YoY	Core CPI MoM (SA)	Core PCE YoY	Core PCE MoM
Aug-26	334.840	3.4	0.20	334.808	3.3	2.3	0.165	3.2	0.164
Sep-26	335.540	3.3	0.29	335.408	3.3	2.2	0.148	3.2	0.206
Oct-26	335.260	3.0	0.00	335.289	#N/A	#N/A	0.131	3.1	0.151
Nov-26	334.630	3.2	0.17	334.659	3.3	2.3	0.159	3.1	0.172
Dec-26	334.390	3.2	0.21	334.302	3.2	2.3	0.159	3.0	0.181
Jan-27	335.590	3.2	0.29	335.150	3.0	2.2	0.182	2.8	0.239
Feb-27	336.790	3.1	0.24	336.096	2.8	2.1	0.182	2.6	0.220
Mar-27	338.310	2.5	0.35	337.051	2.1	2.1	0.161	2.5	0.181
Apr-27	339.390	1.9	0.22	338.029	1.5	1.9	0.155	2.4	0.175
May-27	340.442	1.6	0.25	339.030	1.2	1.8	0.172	2.2	0.157
Jun-27	341.280	2.2	0.21	339.599	1.7	2.0	0.172	2.2	0.157
Jul-27	341.717	2.3	0.20	339.768	1.8	2.0	0.179	2.2	0.162
Aug-27	342.303	2.2	0.23	340.206	1.6	2.0	0.179	2.2	0.162

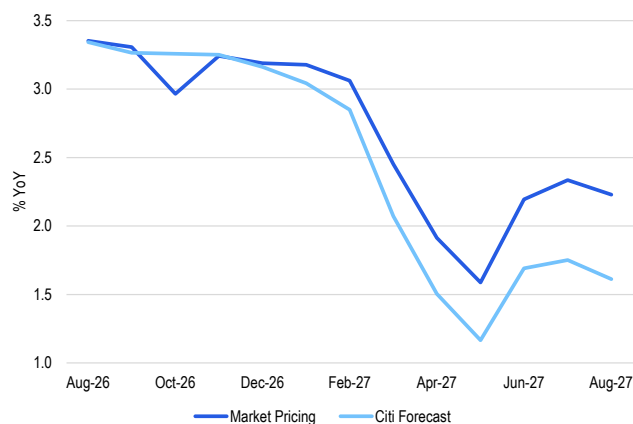
*market implied core CPI using Citi assumptions for energy, food, seasonal factors as of

13-Aug

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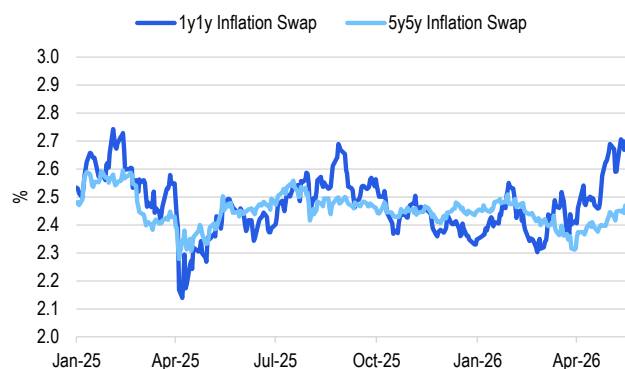
Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg

Figure 14. Citi CPI forecast versus market pricing



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Source: Citi Research

Figure 15. Market forward inflation pricing



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Figure 16. Economic Indicators forecast

		2026F	2027F			2026				2027			
						Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
GDP	%Avg YoY	2.0	1.8	%QoQ Ann		2.1	1.5	1.8	1.8	1.8	1.8	1.8	1.8
Consumption	%Avg YoY	2.0	2.1	%QoQ Ann		0.5	3.2	1.7	1.9	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.1
Business Equip. Investment	%Avg YoY	9.6	4.3	%QoQ Ann		15.8	15.2	5.0	5.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0
Business IPP	%Avg YoY	8.0	1.3	%QoQ Ann		13.8	8.8	3.0	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.5
Business Structures	%Avg YoY	-3.9	2.5	%QoQ Ann		-4.7	-5.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0
Residential Investment	%Avg YoY	-2.9	2.8	%QoQ Ann		-7.8	1.5	2.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0
Final Private Domestic Demand	%Avg YoY	2.5	2.2	%QoQ Ann		1.7	3.9	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.1
Government	%Avg YoY	0.2	0.6	%QoQ Ann		4.4	-0.8	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7
Exports	%Avg YoY	4.5	3.1	%QoQ Ann		10.9	4.5	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0
Imports	%Avg YoY	2.4	3.5	%QoQ Ann		11.8	11.5	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	3.0
Inventories	pp cont.	-0.3	0.0	pp cont.		0.2	-0.7	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Headline PCE Deflator	%Avg YoY	3.5	2.2	%Avg YoY		3.1	3.8	3.6	3.5	2.8	2.0	2.0	1.9
Core PCE Deflator	%Avg YoY	3.2	2.3	%Avg YoY		3.1	3.3	3.2	3.1	2.6	2.3	2.2	2.2
Core CPI	%Avg YoY	2.5	2.0	%Avg YoY		2.5	2.7	2.4	2.3	2.1	1.9	2.0	2.1
Headline CPI	%Avg YoY	3.3	1.9	%Avg YoY		2.7	3.8	3.3	3.2	2.7	1.5	1.6	1.7
Average Hourly Earnings	%Avg YoY	3.2	2.7	%Avg YoY		3.6	3.4	3.0	2.7	2.7	2.7	2.8	2.8
Unemployment Rate	Avg %	4.5	4.3	Avg %		4.3	4.3	4.7	4.6	4.5	4.3	4.2	4.2
Monthly payroll growth	(1,000s) avg.	51.3	50.0	(1,000s) avg.		72.7	77.0	5.7	50.0	50.0	50.0	50.0	50.0
ISM Manf	Avg	52.5	52.0	Avg		52.6	53.3	52.2	52.0	52.0	52.0	52.0	52.0
Policy Range	% EOP	3.0-3.25	2.75-3.0	% EOP		3.5-3.75	3.5-3.75	3.5-3.75	3.0-3.25	2.75-3.0	2.75-3.0	2.75-3.0	2.75-3.0

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